

SER & ESTAR

Essential Guide

A practical guide to the core contrasts in contemporary Mexican Spanish

✗ First: forget the “permanent vs. temporary” rule.

SER and ESTAR do not mean “permanent” and “temporary.”

The choice between SER and ESTAR depends on what you want to express: identity, classification, location, a state, an event, an evaluation, and other functions. Context can also change how an adjective is interpreted.

Start from the function and meaning you need instead.

Compare:

- Puebla está en México.
- Hoy es martes.
- Mi abuelo está muerto.

1 Core Uses

Start by identifying the function you want to express. These are the most productive patterns.

SER	
Use	Examples
Identity and classification	Soy Juan. Es mi hermana.
Profession	Soy maestro. Ana es doctora.
Origin and nationality	Soy de México. Soy mexicano.
Characteristics and descriptions	La casa es azul. Juan es tranquilo.
Possession	La casa es mía. Ese coche es de Ana.
Material	La mesa es de madera.
Time and date	Son las tres. Hoy es martes.
Time and location of events	La clase es mañana. El concierto es a las ocho. La fiesta es en mi casa.

ESTAR	
Use	Examples
Location of people and things	Estoy en casa. Las llaves están en la mesa. Puebla está en México.
Physical and emotional states	Estoy cansado. Está feliz. Está enferma.
Resulting states	La puerta está cerrada. El vaso está roto. Mi abuelo está muerto.
Actions in progress	Estoy trabajando. Estamos comiendo.

2 Events vs. Locations

This contrast is especially useful because English normally uses “to be” in both cases.

SER: an event takes place	ESTAR: a person, thing, or place is located
La fiesta es en mi casa. The party takes place at my house.	Mi casa está en Puebla. My house is in Puebla.
El concierto es en el teatro. The concert takes place at the theater.	El teatro está en el centro. The theater is downtown.

3 Adjectives That Change Meaning

With some adjectives, changing SER to ESTAR changes the interpretation of the adjective itself. Learn these combinations in context rather than trying to predict every meaning from a formula.

With SER	With ESTAR
Es aburrido. — He/it is boring.	Está aburrido. — He is bored.
Es listo. — He is clever.	Está listo. — He is ready.
Es seguro. — It/he is safe or reliable.	Está seguro. — He/she is sure.
Es verde. — It is green.	Está verde. — It is unripe / not ready.
Es rico. — He/she is rich.	Está rico. — It tastes good / is delicious.
Es vivo. — He/she is clever or shrewd.	Está vivo. — He/she is alive.

4 Same Adjective, Different Perspective

Sometimes the adjective keeps its basic meaning, but the verb changes how the speaker presents the description. SER commonly characterizes the subject; ESTAR can present an evaluation grounded in a particular situation or experience.

Characterizing with SER	Evaluating with ESTAR
La película es aburrida. The movie is characterized as boring.	La película estuvo aburrida. The speaker evaluates the movie or experience on that occasion.
El restaurante es bueno. The restaurant is characterized positively.	El restaurante estuvo muy bueno. The speaker evaluates a particular experience positively.
Ana es guapa. Ana is characterized as attractive.	Ana está guapísima hoy. The speaker evaluates how Ana looks in this situation.

5 BUENO, MALO, BIEN & MAL

These four words are extremely common, but they do not belong to the same grammatical category.

Key distinction. BUENO/A and MALO/A are adjectives: they describe or evaluate nouns and change for gender and number. BIEN and MAL are adverbs: they do not change form.

Expression	Common meanings and examples in Mexico
ser bueno/a	To be a good person, have good qualities, or be good at something. Es buena maestra. / Mi hermano es bueno para cocinar.
ser malo/a	To be a bad person, have poor qualities, or be bad at something. Es malo para las matemáticas. / La película es mala.
estar bueno/a	For food: to taste good. El mole está bueno. For a person, it can describe physical attractiveness and may sound sexual; guapo/a is more neutral.
estar malo/a	For food or products: to be spoiled or in bad condition. La leche está mala. For illness, está enfermo/a is the clearer neutral choice in Mexico.
estar bien	To be okay/well, acceptable, or correct. Estoy bien. / La comida está bien. / Está bien así.
estar mal	To be unwell, wrong, incorrect, or in a bad situation. Estoy mal del estómago. / La respuesta está mal. / La situación está mal.

! Important:

BIEN and MAL are not used with SER. Forms such as *es bien and *es mal do not exist in standard Spanish. Use BUENO/A or MALO/A instead: Es bueno. / Es malo.

Notice that bien and mal are not simply the “ESTAR versions” of bueno and malo. They also modify actions and other verbs: Trabaja bien. / Cocina mal. / Me siento bien. / Salió mal.

6 Scope

This guide covers the most useful patterns for choosing between SER and ESTAR. Spanish allows additional uses and nuances that are best learned gradually and in context. The examples in this guide prioritize contemporary Mexican Spanish; meanings and levels of directness can vary by region and context.